

Why Not Ask?

I approach this question by considering a pervasive asymmetry between requests and offers. It is often not okay to request an act, but perfectly fine to accept an offer for it. This asymmetry is puzzling: if the same obligation results from acceptance of a request or offer to do an act, and the request and offer concern the very same act, why should it matter whether the act is introduced by a request or by an offer? I propose that the requests featuring in the asymmetry are wrongful because they create reasons to perform the act requested. This creates a double-bind: if the requestee acts as requested, they pay the *practical* cost of doing so, and if they do not, they pay a *moral* cost, in the form of a reason for regret. This double-bind does not always make requests wrongful, but I illustrate how, in more serious cases, it can be intrusive, coercive, and manipulative. Offers do not create the same double-bind, I argue, because offers do not as such create reasons.

1 Introduction

Suppose we are mere workplace acquaintances. I have a flight coming up and know you have no plans to be near the airport, which is a 30-minute drive for you. I am also an investment banker with plenty of disposable income, and the metro takes 35 minutes and costs \$5. In this context, you would likely be put off by my request for a ride to the airport, but not by my acceptance of your offer to give me one. I will call this the *Requesting-Offering Asymmetry*.

The asymmetry is common. It is typically not okay to request a bite of an acquaintance's dessert, or their jacket to keep you warm. But it is perfectly fine to accept these if offered. The asymmetry arises in particular with respect to expressive acts: even if someone owes you an apology for blocking your view of a concert, it is wrong (not to mention self-defeating) to request their apology, but fine to accept it if offered. The asymmetry can arise among intimates and when the act in question is required. There is nothing wrong with accepting a friend's offer to return the five dollars they borrowed three weeks ago. But if it is a trivial amount of money to all parties involved, most would be put off by a request for the cash—it would be petty to keep tabs on such small debts in a friendship. The asymmetry even arises when the stakes are high. I should not ask my sister for her kidney, but it is fine to accept it if offered—assuming, of course, that she is a healthy match and well-informed.

The asymmetry is pervasive, but puzzling. The request and offer concern the same act, so the reasons bearing on the act should be the same, either way. But if the act and the reasons bearing on it are the same, why should it matter whether the act is introduced as a possibility by a request or by an offer? Further, the obligations created by acceptance of the Airport Request or the Airport Offer are identical: in either case, you incur an obligation to drive me to the airport by willingly agreeing to do so. But how can my request and your offer result in the same obligation upon their acceptance, when my request wrongs you, and my acceptance of your offer does not? To sum up the puzzle: If the agreements formed by way of request and offer are symmetrical in their *inputs*—that is, the act they concern—and in their *outputs*—that is, the obligations they create—then how can they be asymmetrical in the permissibility of a party entering into them, by making a request or accepting a corresponding offer?

Past work on offers primarily concerns offers to exchange goods for mutual benefit (Zwolinski, Ferguson, & Wertheimer 2022), rather than the offers to do favors that feature in the Requesting-Offering Asymmetry.¹ Past work on requests has primarily concerned the nature of the obligations or reasons created by requests (e.g., Cupit 1994, Enoch 2011, Raz 2009, Lewis 2018, Gläser 2019, Schaber 2021, Weltman 2022a, 2022b, 2023), rather than the permissibility of making requests. Further, existing accounts of how requests can be wrongful either assume that requests in general fail to create reasons (Laskowski & Silver 2021), or else restrict attention to a certain class of wrongful requests, for example requests that fail to create reasons (Khokhar 2026), requests for empathy with racist, oppressive, or otherwise vicious perspectives (Pohlhaus

¹ A notable exception is de Kenessey (2023), who argues that the duties resulting from accepted offers and requests derive from shared reasoning about what to do. On this view, requests and offers are symmetrical proposals in joint deliberation, differing only in that a request proposes that the *addressee* perform the act in question, whereas an offer proposes that the *addressor* perform it. Parties to deliberation are symmetrically situated, insofar as what matters is not who makes the proposal, but rather which action is favored by the balance of shared reasons (de Kenessey 2023, §1.3, §3.3). This view makes the Requesting-Offering Asymmetry especially puzzling. Why is it wrong for me to make a proposal by requesting, but perfectly acceptable for you to make the same proposal by offering, if the same shared reasons bear on the act in question either way?

2021), or requests that fail to trust our intimates to live up to their special duties (Lewis 2024). By contrast, the Requesting-Offering Asymmetry calls for a general explanation, which applies even outside of these special contexts: it requires an account of how requests among intimates and strangers alike can be wrongful, even when they create reasons, and even when the act requested is permissible.

On the account I propose, requests can be wrongful *because they create reasons*. By creating a reason, a request creates a double-bind: if the requestee acts as requested, they pay the *practical* cost of doing so, and if they do not, they pay a *moral* cost, in the form of a reason for regret. While this double-bind does not make all requests wrongful, it can suffice to do so, when the requestee's objection to being put in a double-bind is sufficiently strong relative to the other considerations in play. Offers do not create the same double-bind, I argue, because offers do not as such create reasons. In Section 2, I develop my view, the *Normative Power Account*. In Section 3, I consider several alternative explanations, which appeal to politeness, intrusion, coercion, and manipulation. In each case, I argue that the proposed explanation fails, or that it is incomplete and can be improved by the Normative Power Account. Section 4 concludes.

2 The Normative Power Account

I propose the following explanation of the asymmetry. My request provides a reason for you to do the requested act, and this reason sets back your interests. Standardly, this is because my request puts you in a *double-bind*. If you grant my request, I impose a *practical* burden on you: you perform a costly act. If you do not grant my request, I impose a *moral* burden on you: you now have a reason to regret that you did not grant it. Either way, by requesting, I exercise a normative power to provide you with a reason that unilaterally sets back your interests. When

these interests are weighty enough, compared to the other considerations in play, my request wrongs you.²

Offers, by contrast, do not as such exercise normative powers to create reasons, though they characteristically express consent to the costs associated with their acceptance. When requesting is wrongful and accepting an offer is not, this is because the former, but not the latter, unilaterally exercises a normative power to provide a reason, which sets back the interests of the addressee; this is the Normative Power Account of the asymmetry. I'll first explain the sense in which requests but not offers create reasons. Then I'll show how the Normative Power Account explains the asymmetry.

2.1 Offers and Reasons

A *normative power* is an ability to control a normative condition at will (Raz 2022). Requests, promises, commands, and acts of consent are often viewed as normative powers. I will not propose an account of offers here. As I'll now explain, even if offers exercise normative powers, my view implies that offers do not *as such* exercise normative powers *to create reasons*.

This is independently plausible, because acceptance of an offer is not as such rationally motivating. Unlike a motive to do what was requested “simply because they asked,” a motive to accept an offer “simply because they offered” is not intelligible. If I tell you that I accepted an offer, you will naturally infer that I had independent reasons, besides the sheer fact of offering, to do so. For example, you may infer that I independently wanted what was offered, that I thought accepting the offer would make the offeror happy, or that I felt social pressure to accept it. By

² Here I am appealing to the idea that other things equal, my act wrongs you if (i) it sets back your interests, and (ii) an alternative act available to me would not have set back anyone's interests as much (e.g., Wallace 2019, Ch. 5). A wrongdoing is an unexcused act which violates a duty which is *directed*, i.e. owed to someone. Such violations generally create reasons for the wrongdoer to apologize and compensate the victim, and for the victim to blame the wrongdoer. Directed duties might conflict while bearing on the wider question of what is impermissible (e.g., as in the case of conflicting promises; Owens 2016). Thus wrongings are *pro tanto*, in the sense that they might not always suffice to make an act impermissible, but *strict*, in the sense that they always ground facts about apology, compensation, and blame (Maguire & Lord 2016).

contrast, if it is clear that the requester had the standing to issue the request, their standing may admit further explanation, but it makes perfect sense for me to be motivated to do what was requested, simply because it was requested.

While offers do not *as such* exercise normative powers to create reasons, an offer can exercise a power to create reasons when it is also a request, a promise, or some other act which exercises that power. For example, a party invitation offers hospitality and often implicitly communicates a request to attend. This is an offer, which gives the invited party a reason to attend. But the offer does not *as such* exercise a normative power to create reasons: it does so only because it is also a request.

Offers may also trigger reasons already applying to the addressee. For example, the awkwardness of refusing an offer may trigger your general reasons to avoid uncomfortable situations, and thus give you a reason to accept the offer. Or you may have a reason to use my trampoline because you want to, conditional on my consent to your use of it, and my offer may trigger this condition by expressing my consent. Still, unlike requests, these offers do not exercise a normative power to create reasons.³

That said, offers standardly express consent to the costs associated with their acceptance. If I make an offer rationally, freely, sincerely, and permissibly, and I am well-informed about the circumstances, including the costs to me and benefits to you, then my offer expresses my informed and effective consent. You do not need to weigh the costs to me of doing the act in determining whether you will wrong me by accepting my offer. The effect of my consent is

³ One might say that an offer provides a *conditional reason* for the addressee to accept *if they want to*. But it is unclear what the postulation of such a reason would explain, which cannot be explained by the observations made already, namely (i) that offers may simultaneously be requests, expressions of desires, and so on, and (ii) that sometimes offers trigger independent reasons.

precisely to render these costs permissible—though the costs may be relevant in other ways, for example in determining the duties of reciprocity you incur by accepting my offer.

2.2 Requests and Reasons

The claim that requests exercise a normative power to create reasons is typically supported by two observations. First, as mentioned above, it makes sense to do an act for someone “simply because they asked” (e.g., Owens 2012, p. 86; McMyler 2017, p. 79; Gläser 2019, p. 29). Further, we often distinguish this motive from related ones. If a friend asks for help moving and I agree, I may be moved directly by their reason for asking: my assistance will materially benefit them, by allowing them to move in one day rather than two. But their request makes available a further motive: I may, in addition, be moved by the fact that they asked me for help. Plausibly, this is an intelligible motivating reason because requests provide normative reasons, which can then motivate us.

Second, the idea that requests create reasons helps to distinguish requests from commands. Requests create *pro tanto* reasons, which are generally more easily outweighed or undercut than the obligations created by commands (Raz 2009, pp. 14-15; Lance & Kukla 2013, p. 460; Lewis 2018, p. 11). In turn, the idea that requests and commands create new reasons (or obligations) helps to distinguish requests and commands from advice and demands, which seek to inform the addressee of reasons (or obligations) that are already in play, without introducing new ones.

The claim that requests exercise a power to create reasons is widely held (Cupit 1994; Raz 2009, pp. 14-15; Owens 2012, pp. 86-7, 98-100, 228-9; Lance & Kukla 2013, pp. 460-3; Little 2013, pp. 131-5; Lewis 2018; Schaber 2021; Khokhar 2026). There are many different

accounts of how requests create reasons, and this paper will not adjudicate between them.⁴ In this section, I assume that requests create reasons. I will later raise problems for *epistemicism*, the view that requests do not create new reasons in any systematic way, but instead merely call attention to reasons that exist already (Laskowski & Silver 2021; Weltman 2022a, 2022b, 2023).

To explain the asymmetry, I appeal to the idea that a wrongful request can sometimes provide a reason. On this point it is useful to compare requests with commands. The ability of a person to issue a binding command does not evaporate upon conflict with their duties. Imagine a father telling his teenage son to take on additional chores at home, even though the son is already struggling to manage school and a part-time job. Plausibly, the father creates a reason for his son to spend a few more hours on chores each week, by telling him to do so. But I think we can coherently imagine a version of the case where the father thereby wrongs his son. Some theorists go further, arguing that an authority like a judge can permissibly *coercively enforce* wrongful commands, such that its subjects are *not entitled to compensation* for the harms they experience as a result of these commands, e.g. via punishments (Viehoff 2019). But here the point is more basic: normative powers like commands and requests tolerate occasional and limited misuse.⁵

Importantly, this does not imply (for example) that a request that another commit murder provides them with a reason to do so. For I am not making the stronger assumption that a request

⁴ Cupit (1994) argues that requests create reasons to respect the trust that the request placed in the requestee. Lewis (2018), Schaber (2021), and Khokhar (2026) propose that requests create reasons by sustaining valuable relationships. Mossé (2026) argues that requests create reasons because they thereby improve compliance with duties.

⁵ Where to draw the line? That is, what distinguishes wrongful requests that create reasons from those that do not? After all, some requests for permissible acts fail to create reasons. If a bigoted person tells Fatima, a Muslim woman, that he is uncomfortable with her hijab and asks her to remove it (Khokhar 2026), this wrongful request does not create a reason, even though the act requested (removing the hijab) is permissible. My view is that requests create reasons when (and because) the act requested falls under an imperfect duty applying to the requestee (Mossé 2026). Requests for murder do not create reasons, because we lack imperfect duties to murder. Similarly, the request to remove the hijab does not create a reason, because removing it does not fall under an imperfect duty—we may have an imperfect duty to assist others in dealing with legitimate forms of discomfort, but the bigot’s discomfort is not legitimate, as it is based on prejudice. Still, we can wrong others by asking them for acts that fall under their imperfect duties (e.g. a ride to the airport), which is why wrongful requests create reasons.

can create a reason when the act requested is *independently wrong*.⁶ I do not use this stronger assumption because the asymmetry only arises when the requested act is not independently wrong to begin with. Consider the cases mentioned earlier: it is permissible to help a colleague get to the airport, to give another person permission to use your jacket, to return borrowed money to a friend, or to donate an organ to a loved one. In each case, it is possible, permissible, and rational for the requestee to do the act in question—that is part of the puzzle. In general, when an act is independently wrong, it is standardly both wrong to request and wrong to accept an offer for its performance. This means that the logical space for the asymmetry is absent.

2.3 The Double-Bind

The Normative Power Account says that when the asymmetry arises, the wrongfulness of requesting is explained by the fact that it provides a reason, which sets back the interests of the addressee. The account thus applies only when these interests are sufficiently weighty, relative to the other interests at play, to make the request count as wrongful. When you comply with my request that you pass the salt, or that you save me from drowning by throwing me a life jacket, you pay some cost, but my request does not wrong you, because your interests are not weighty enough relative to the other interests at play.

Most commonly, the requestee's interests are set back because the request puts them in a double-bind, by imposing a *practical* burden if the request is granted, and a *moral* burden if it is not. This wrongs the requestee by attaching costs to the options available to them, thereby giving them a worse choice situation than the one they are entitled to have.⁷ The practical burden is simply whatever costs are associated with deliberating about and performing the act in question.⁸

⁶ For discussion of the analogous view of promising, see Shiffrin (2011) and Owens (2016).

⁷ See Kolodny (2017, pp. 94-95) for the view that threats can be similarly wrongful, and see Dougherty (2024) for the view that proposals of actions can be similarly wrongful.

⁸ The relevant costs need not be harmful. In Ripstein's (2006) famous example, "I let myself into your home, using burglary tools that do no damage to your locks, and take a nap in your bed. I make sure everything is clean. I bring hypoallergenic and lint-free pajamas and a hairnet....By any ordinary understanding of harm, I do you no harm." I

The moral burden is a reason to regret not granting the request. To *regret* an event is to prefer in part that it had been otherwise in some respect (Wallace 2013, pp. 5-6). Regret need not be *all-in*, in the sense of involving “a stable reaction of sorrow or pain about a past action or circumstance” and “an on-balance preference that things should have been otherwise” (Wallace 2013, pp. 51-2).⁹ I will now explain how requests give us reasons for regret, why these reasons are objectionable burdens, and how they differ from our reasons to regret failing to make an offer (or to follow through on one).

When we choose not to do an act, the reasons that favored it might not become reasons for regret. If you are offered a million dollars or one dollar, and you choose to take a million, you have no reason to regret not taking one dollar instead. But when we pass up an alternative which would have helped another person, and we thereby fail to affirm an important value, regret is fitting. In the case of declining a request, our regret need not always indicate that we take a special interest in *making the requester happy*. Instead, we may aptly regret our failure to affirm the *value* that gave the requester the power to create a reason by requesting.

To illustrate, suppose that the power to create reasons by requesting is justified by the fact that requesting is a valuable social practice, which helps us to better comply with our independent reasons to express good will to others.¹⁰ In that case, I claim that in granting the

use the notions of burdens, costs, and interests in a wide sense: privacy violations would count as burdens or costs, which set back the victim’s interests, even if they are not harmful. In general, I impose a burden or cost on you, which sets back your interests, when you have a normative reason for objecting to my action on your own behalf.

⁹ The flipside of regret is disappointment: when I regret not performing an action, my choice may be less than ideal for someone, who can fittingly be disappointed that I did not act as they had hoped. Such disappointment does not require disappointment *in me* for acting as I did. To illustrate: when my similarly qualified colleague gets a promotion instead of me, it may be fitting for me to be disappointed that my colleague received the promotion. But it is not fitting for me to be disappointed in my colleague for receiving the promotion, supposing that the selection process was procedurally fair, that my colleague was in fact at least as qualified, and that my colleague’s acceptance of the promotion is not in some way a betrayal of our relationship. See Telech & Katz (2022) for a related distinction between propositional disappointment that a hoped-for state of affairs did not transpire and condemnatory disappointment, a form of blame.

¹⁰ We might imagine that it is *built into the concept of a request* that a request aims to improve compliance with our independent reasons to express good will to others. Or we might imagine that the practice of requesting is

request, a morally motivated requestee affirms the value of expressing good will to one another. In declining the request, the requestee would have a reason to regret that they did not express good will, even if they were not especially concerned with the requester's happiness in particular.

If you decline a request which gives you a reason to regret not granting it, this reason suffices to make a degree of regret fitting. It may also be fitting to feel (say) relief upon deciding not to do the act requested. But rather than undermining regret, this just shows that a complex reaction, mixing both regret and relief, is fitting.¹¹ Fitting responses are not always required (Berker 2023, p. 37), but when you decline a request which created a reason for regret, regret is fitting, and thus part of a fully rational emotional response.

In general, it can be objectionable to be put in a position where your interests would be set back if you were fully rational. For example, when taking another's interests into account, we often ought to assign the maximum weight to their interests that they could permissibly and rationally assign to their interests (Voorhoeve 2014, pp. 72-74), as well as the maximum degree of risk-aversion they could permissibly and rationally adopt (Buchak 2017, p. 631). An act that fails to do so can be objectionable, even if the injured party happens not to assign especially high weight to their interests, and even if they happen not to be especially risk averse. The act in question is objectionable simply because it puts this person in a position where their interests would be set back, if they were to respond to the situation in a rational way. In the same way, the act of requesting can be objectionable simply because it puts a person in a position where their interests would be set back, if they were to respond to the situation by feeling rational regret—even if the requestee happens not to feel regret on this occasion.

intelligible independently of this aim, but that our tendency to treat requests as providing reasons is justified by the fact we further this aim in doing so. I have the latter in mind, but the point in the main text makes sense either way.

¹¹ For discussion of how fit-making considerations interact to suggest a more complex reaction, rather than undermining each other, see for example Maguire (2018, pp. 780, 787-8) and Berker (2024).

Even if the strength of the reason created by my request is weak, the strength of your interest in not being made to feel regret can be strong. Regret can be intrusive and frustrating and can cast a shadow over what would have been a friendly and pleasant interaction. Further, repeated regrettable failures to respond to value will erode your conception of yourself as fittingly responsive to it. These interests in not feeling regret are intensified when the requester has failed to properly take them into account.

Our interests in not feeling regret do not always give us complaints against others. For example, suppose I decide to sell my painting, and you decide not to buy it. You may regret your decision, but that does not give you a complaint against me.¹² The case of requesting is importantly different. (i) The requester singles out the requestee, by creating a reason for them *in particular*, and (ii) in requesting, a requester wields a power to *unilaterally create* a reason *at will*. (iii) Further, when you turn down a request, your regret is not felt *prudentially, for your own sake*, but *morally, for another's sake*. (iv) It is not only the reason for regret that is objectionable, but also the fact that the alternative to regret is an act which comes with a practical cost. So I agree that we cannot always object to being made to feel regret. But we can raise this objection when another has (i) singled us out and (ii) unilaterally created a reason at will for us (iii) to regret not helping them, and (iv) the alternative is costly.

If I choose not to help you when I am well-positioned to do so, I may have a reason for regret. But this reason is not one that you created at will for me in particular. Similarly, if you accept my offer to help you, and I fail to help, I have a reason for regret. But my reason for regret does not give me grounds to object to your acceptance of my offer. When you accept my offer, which expresses my consent, we create the resulting reason together—you do not impose it on me unilaterally. Thus the four features (i)-(iv) explain why a reason for regret upon declining a

¹² Thanks to Daniel Viehoff for discussion of this case.

request can ground an objection against another—unlike our reasons to regret not buying a painting, to regret not helping another, or to regret not following through on an accepted offer.

The idea that requests exercise a normative power is essential to my account of the reason for regret: this reason is explained by the *value* that justifies the power to request, and this reason licenses a complaint only because normative powers grant us *at-will control* over others. In a way, it should be unsurprising that those who wield a normative power carry some responsibility for the ways their addressees will be affected by a failure to comply. Requesters wield power over others, and the values served by this power constrain its permissible use. The same is true of commands: parents should not issue overly demanding commands to their children, in part because their children will be made to feel guilty for falling short of them.

2.4 Pluralism

The Normative Power Account identifies a unifying feature of the requests that feature in the asymmetry: unlike offers, they unilaterally exercise a normative power to provide a reason, thereby setting back the interests of the addressee. A request standardly sets back the requestee's interests by creating a double-bind. However, this double-bind does not always arise—there may be no cost to performing the act requested—and a variety of interests may be set back when a request creates a reason. Here are three examples to illustrate.

First, the wrongfulness of requesting is sometimes owed to the *expressive significance* of creating a reason. For example, if I request that you thank me for the dinner I just made you, the reason created by my request can send the insulting message that you would not have been sufficiently motivated to convey gratitude without the reason I provided. What is wrongful in this case is the *message sent* by the request.¹³

¹³ Other accounts of wrongful requests appeal exclusively to the idea that requests can send the insulting message that the requestee would not be sufficiently motivated to comply with their moral obligations (Laskowski & Silver 2021) or with their duties as members of a special relationship (Lewis 2024). The Normative Power Account

Second, creating a reason can be wrongful because it *detracts from the value of a relationship* between requester and requestee. Indeed, many friendships are partly made valuable by a reciprocal pattern of spontaneous favors. To upset this pattern by providing reasons for another to do what they might have done spontaneously can detract from the value of the relationship, and thereby set back an interest of the requestee in its value. In such a case, the wrongfulness of the request is explained by the way that the reason provided by the request detracts from the value of the relationship.

Third, the reason created by a request can set back the interests of the requestee by *contributing to a pattern* of similar setbacks over time. For example, suppose that Natalya's coworker Emory requests emotional support, and that others in the office regularly make such requests of Natalya. If Emory is not asking for a therapy session, but for a brief opportunity to unpack a frustrating work-related experience, his request arguably exercises a normative power to provide Natalya with a reason to help him. Even so, Emory's request may be wrongful, because it belongs to a *pattern* of such requests from others in the office, which cumulatively leads Natalya to take on uncompensated emotional labor, while impeding her ability to do other (compensated) work.¹⁴

In summary, the Normative Power Account is pluralist. It allows that the reason provided by a request can set back a *variety* of the requestee's interests, for example by creating a double-bind, or by detracting from the value of a relationship. As the next section explains, the

identifies a similar expressive wrong, namely the insulting message that the requestee would not be sufficiently motivated, absent the reason provided by the request. But for the Normative Power Account, this insulting message is just one of several ways that the reasons provided by requests can wrong others. Whereas the accounts just mentioned apply only when there is an antecedent obligation or intimate relationship, we saw in the introduction that the asymmetry can arise outside of these special contexts, and the Normative Power Account is not similarly restricted to these contexts.

¹⁴ In such a case, the standing to request can become an instrument of oppressive power. This is the counterpart of Young's (2004) observation that oppressive powerlessness consists partly in a loss of respect, where treating another with respect requires that one "do what they request because they have some authority, expertise, or influence."

Normative Power Account is pluralist in a further sense: it is compatible with the observation that particular requests featuring in the asymmetry may be wrongful for a variety of reasons.

3 Alternative Explanations of the Requesting-Offering Asymmetry

This section assesses alternative explanations of the asymmetry, which appeal to politeness, intrusion, coercion, and manipulation. In each case, I argue that the proposed explanation fails or that it is incomplete and can be improved by the Normative Power Account.

3.1 Politeness

One might propose that requests do not create reasons, and that the requests featuring in the asymmetry are wrong simply because they send impolite messages. By contrast, the corresponding offers abide by the relevant standards of politeness, civility, or etiquette.

On the first way of spelling out this view, the relevant requests send a *generic impolite message*, for example the message that the requester lacks good will.¹⁵ My objection is that this account comes dangerously close to restating what we were hoping to explain. Why do these requests fail to express good will, when accepting the corresponding offers does not? My account identifies a robust difference between requests and offers: requests create reasons to pay costs, whereas offers express consent to these costs. The appeal to generic impolite messages is significantly less explanatory: it just stipulates that conventions of politeness rule out certain requests, but not acceptance of the corresponding offers.¹⁶

On a different approach, the relevant requests send specific insulting messages, for example the message that the requestee would not be sufficiently motivated to comply with their moral obligations (Laskowski & Silver 2021) or with their duties as members of a special

¹⁵ Standards of politeness or civility are often expressive (Calhoun 2000, p. 260): they give us ways of expressing to others that we are good-willed and respect their personhood and agency (Buss 1999, Valentini 2021), even when adhering to the relevant standards requires little conscious thought (Olberding 2016, pp. 439-442).

¹⁶ A convention is reproduced over time partly due to the weight of precedent (Millikan 1998, p. 162), and thus may be morally binding in part because it is recognized as binding (Owens 2022, p. 1). I am arguing that conventions cannot carry all of the explanatory weight. Below, I explain how conventions are relevant to the asymmetry.

relationship (Lewis 2024). Of course, one worry with such proposals is extensional: we have seen that the asymmetry arises even among strangers, and even when there is no prior obligation to perform the act in question.

Further, I argued above that the Normative Power Account can explain how requests commit expressive wrongs. The view under consideration represents an alternative to this account, rather than a notational variant of it, because its proponents pair it with epistemicism, the claim that in general, requests do not create new reasons in any systematic way, but instead merely call attention to reasons that exist already (Laskowski & Silver 2021; Weltman 2022a, 2022b, 2023). While a comprehensive assessment of epistemicism lies beyond the scope of this paper, here I will register three worries for it.

First, epistemicism struggles to distinguish requests from other forms of second-personal address. After all, many acts point to pre-existing reasons, including expressions of desires or wishes (Schaber 2021; Weltman 2022b, 1733–1736, 2023, 398–399), advice, and demands. Distinguishing these from requests is a non-trivial task, given that some theorists draw the needed distinctions precisely by appealing to the idea that requests create reasons (Mossé 2026).

Second, epistemicism is attractive because it is parsimonious. It dissolves the mystery of how we could create reasons at will by denying that we ever do, since a request merely draws attention to reasons that are already there. But this parsimony is unprincipled, if it is focused only on requests, and we are prepared to accept that we can change normative facts at will in other ways, for example by promising, consenting, or commanding. The parsimony that motivates epistemicism is attractive only when it is combined with the more radical view that we *never* change normative facts at will, a view which I will treat as off the table.

Finally, epistemicists need an error theory to explain away the fact that we often treat

requests as creating reasons. You are not required to stop and help every lost tourist you see, even if you know that they desire help. But when a stranger asks for directions, you will feel that your situation has changed and that you now have a reason to help this person. Epistemicists need to explain this. Given that you were well aware of your reasons prior to the stranger's request, what does the request add? Epistemicists may give answers to this question, for example by appealing to social pressure (which I discuss below). But these error theories detract from the parsimony that was supposed to make the theory attractive in the first place.

We should reject these appeals to politeness, but it is important that we recognize the role that cultural norms play in creating the asymmetry. To explain the Requesting-Offering Asymmetry, I proposed that unlike offers, requests create reasons. But whether a particular request creates a reason, and indeed whether a particular communicative act counts as a request or offer—as opposed to, say, a command, invitation, or mere expression of a desire—is culturally dependent. As a result, whether the asymmetry arises, and the degree to which the request in question is objectionable, will depend on cultural norms.

3.2 Rights against Intrusion

One possible explanation posits a right against intrusion, which protects us, for example, from relative strangers' personal concerns. For example, I should not rope an unsuspecting stranger into helping me with a book project. Perhaps you have a right against intrusion, which is violated by my Airport Request but waived by your Airport Offer.

The wrong of intrusion could be traced to the deliberative costs on strangers of thinking about our problems; to the fact that the meaningfulness or importance to my identity of a project does not in itself generate a strong demand on others for active assistance (Scanlon 1975, White 2017); or to the importance of autonomously handling the minor inconveniences in one's life.

However, these considerations do not suffice to explain the asymmetry. First, in the case of the Airport Request, we can suppose it is common knowledge that the deliberative cost of changing up your plans is insignificant: you were planning on going grocery shopping that evening, but there is another grocery store near the airport, and the date and time are determined by my flight. Requesting still seems out of place. Second, getting a ride to the airport is not especially meaningful or important to my identity. Finally, we often want others to autonomously handle their own minor inconveniences—you might feel put off if a stranger asked you to take a seat on the ground and tie their shoes. But you would also likely be insulted if a stranger saw you struggling with your laces and offered to tie them for you. In this way, appeals to the importance of autonomously resolving an inconvenience are often symmetrical, ruling out demeaning requests and condescending offers alike.

There is a more general problem with the appeal to intrusion: it is not clear that there is a single moral objection to intrusiveness as such. Instead, we have a cluster of loosely related objections, relating to deliberative costs, meaningfulness, and autonomy, for example (cf. Thomson 1975, pp. 312-313). For that reason, it can seem explanatorily idle to postulate a right against intrusion, which is waived by the request and violated by the offer. The Normative Power Account explains the intrusiveness of the relevant requests in a different way. These requests create reasons which intrude on the normative circumstances of the requestee. They standardly do so by putting the requestee in a double-bind, which makes them either pay a practical cost by granting the request or else pay a moral cost by declining it.

3.3 Coercive Social Pressure

One might say that the requests that feature in the asymmetry are wrongful because they create coercive social pressure. Social pressure, in the relevant sense, is the prospect of a socially

unpleasant (e.g. embarrassing or otherwise awkward) experience. We can distinguish a few kinds of social pressure associated with the Airport Request. First, if you do not accept my request, you may appear ungenerous to observers; this is the pressure *to appear virtuous* (Benziman 2023, p. 301). Second, if you do not accept my request, perhaps you suggest that I did not have good reasons for requesting (de Kenessey 2017, p. 115); this is the pressure *to avoid insulting the requester*. Third, if you do not accept my request, you will disappoint me, and it is unpleasant to disappoint others; this is the pressure *to avoid disappointing the requester*. In all these ways, a request can create the coercive prospect of a socially unpleasant experience, which forces the requestee to accept the request or to justify their choice to decline it. An offer, by contrast, reveals that the act in question would not be an inconvenient favor performed out of social pressure, but something which the offeror would genuinely like to do.

Coercive social pressure seems explanatory in many cases, but it cannot fully explain the Requesting-Offering Asymmetry, for two reasons. First, we can remove the social pressure by assuming that the requestee is socially graceful. Suppose the requestee can quickly and effortlessly whip up a plausible, sincere excuse: “Sorry, but I think I won’t have the time to give you a ride to the airport.” With this excuse in hand, the requestee can avoid appearing vicious or insulting the requester. Suppose, further, that the requester shows no signs of disappointment, and expresses that they have no expectation that the favor will be performed. The social pressure is greatly reduced, but the asymmetry persists: requesting apology, or that a friend repay a \$5 loan, still seems wrong, even if the requestee is socially graceful and the requester is careful not to convey disappointment.

Second, part of the puzzle was that the request and offer are symmetrical in the obligations created by their acceptance, but asymmetrical in their permissibility. However, if the

request is simply a coercive form of social pressure, it is unclear why giving in to such pressure amounts to incurring an obligation. If a bully coercively gets you to agree to give them your lunch later today, you may have reasons of self-interest to follow through, but your commitment to giving them your lunch is not a valid, independently binding agreement. More generally, agreements reached through wrongful coercion are often thought not to be binding. It remains puzzling, then, that if you accept the Airport Request, you thereby incur an obligation.

In reply, one might stipulate that there is a “sweet spot” of agreements which are coercive enough to be wrongful, but not coercive enough to lose their bindingness. This stipulation is forced on us if we appeal to coercive social pressure, understood as the prospect of a socially awkward experience. But the Normative Power Account has no need for this stipulation, because it appeals to a different kind of pressure: in issuing a request, we can pressure others by creating reasons for them to do what we ask. This pressure is standardly created via a double-bind, i.e. a practical burden if the request is accepted and a moral burden if it is not.

The Normative Power Account fares better with respect to both of the above worries. First, it applies even when the requestee is socially graceful, and the requester expresses no disappointment—even in such cases, requests create reasons. Second, the Normative Power Account does not make it mysterious why the requests that feature in the asymmetry are binding: the request created a genuine reason, and agreeing to act on that reason constitutes a genuinely binding agreement.

Of course, one might further develop the Normative Power Account by claiming that requests create reasons *by creating the prospect of a socially awkward experience*. Or one might add that social pressure can *exacerbate* the wrongfulness of a request, which already wronged

the requestee by creating reasons. But these ways of appealing to social pressure are elaborations of the Normative Power Account, not a substantive alternative to it.

3.4 Manipulation

One might argue that the relevant requests are wrongful because they *manipulate* the requestee. There are three importantly different ways of characterizing manipulation. One might say that to manipulate a person is (i) to bypass their deliberation, (ii) to deceive them about their reasons, or (iii) to pressure them into performing an action (Noggle 2022, §2). I considered pressure in the previous section. In this section, I will first explain how the relevant requests might (i) bypass the requestee's deliberation or (ii) deceive them about their reasons. I will then argue that neither of these kinds of manipulation provides a full account of the asymmetry.

The first option is to imagine that the requestee acts from a *habit* of granting others' requests, which involves not deliberating carefully on a given occasion about the merits of doing the act requested (Owens 2012, pp. 79-82). It is not in general wrong to trigger this habit by making a request, even though doing so bypasses the requestee's deliberation. But perhaps it is wrongful to trigger this habit when one's request does not in fact create a reason, since the point of the habit is to respond appropriately to requests. On this explanation of the asymmetry, the relevant requests do not create reasons and thereby exploit the requestee's tendency to simply do what was asked.¹⁷

The second option is to imagine that the requestee acts from an assessment of their reasons, but that the relevant requests wrongfully *deceive* the requestee about their reasons.

Suppose that the relevant requests do not create reasons. Even so, a requester *presupposes*

¹⁷ On an alternative view, the relevant requests are wrongful because the requestee pays the costs of doing the act requested, and the requestee has sufficiently strong interests in having the opportunity to deliberate about whether to pay these costs. However, the request seems objectionable *regardless of whether it is granted*. Explanations that appeal only to the practical cost of granting the request cannot explain this, since this cost is only realized if the request is granted. By contrast, on my view, the relevant change in the requestee's circumstances occurs not when they grant the request, but when the request is made, because they then have a reason to perform the act in question.

entitlement to request, taking it for granted in the conversation. Just as an assertion that I need to pick up my son from school will lead a conversationally cooperative hearer to accommodate the presupposition that I have a son (Stalnaker 2002), a request will lead a cooperative requestee to accommodate the presupposition that the speaker was entitled to request, and thus created a reason. Further, a minimally conscientious requestee who believes it possible that a request provided a reason would want to err on the side of helping, to avoid risking a selfish failure to respond appropriately. On this explanation of the asymmetry, the relevant requests manipulate the conscientious and cooperative requestee, by misrepresenting their normative situation and taking advantage of their tendency to accommodate this misrepresentation.

I am open to the possibility that we can wrong others by misrepresenting their normative situation and creating an apparent double-bind: if the requestee acts as requested, they perform a costly act, and if they do not, they might feel regret. However, there is no need to assume, as the appeal to manipulation does, that the asymmetry can arise only when the relevant request does not provide a reason, or when the requester is not sure whether it provided them with a reason. Requests can be wrongful simply because they create reasons which set back the addressee's interests. Indeed, the requestee may be frustrated precisely because they *know* that they now have a cumbersome reason for action, which puts them in an actual double-bind: if they act on this reason, they perform a costly act, and if they do not, they will be left with a reason for regret.

4 Conclusion

This paper proposed the Normative Power Account of the Requesting-Offering Asymmetry. On this account, the asymmetry is explained by the fact that offers do not as such create reasons, whereas requests can exercise a normative power to create reasons, and can wrongfully set back

the interests of the addressee by doing so. In using the Requesting-Offering Asymmetry to characterize the normative power wielded by requesters, this paper is proposing that comparing relevantly similar uses of different forms of second-personal address can shed light on how the values they serve constrain their permissible use. This is *the comparative approach* to second-personal address. The Requesting-Offering Asymmetry is just one of a family of similar asymmetries, for example between offering and inviting, and between requesting and commanding (Owens 2012, p. 206). These further asymmetries are a natural next step for the comparative approach.

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